

PART THREE

The Value of Dissent, Culture and

Nonconformity

THE VANISHING

AMERICANS

I recently had occasion to give a dinner party in London for a rather widely assorted group of friends and acquaintances. Among the guests was an outspoken Socialist I've known for many years. When the table conversation lagged, he seized the opportunity to deliver a political monolog, expressing views which were more than slightly left of center.

To my amusement, one of my other guests, a vacationing American businessman, later felt constrained to ask me how I, a "leading Capitalist," could tolerate the presence of such a wild radical at my dinner table.

"Aren't you afraid to have a man like that around you, spouting all those dangerous theories?" he asked.

Keeping a straight face, I tried to explain that Socialism is an entirely respectable political ideology in Great Britain, adding, for what I hoped was proper snob-

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appealing emphasis, that Socialists are even received at Buckingham Palace by Her Majesty, the Queen.

I assured my worried fellow countryman I didn't really consider the theories we'd heard expounded at all dangerous. I said I hoped my own convictions weren't built on such shifting foundations that a ten-minute tirade by a Socialist zealot could undermine them or corrupt me.